FLO4PAWS · SCENTWORK SERIES

Scentwork Level 2: Bigger Searches

The next step after *Basic Scentwork for Every Dog*. A Flo4Paws resource.

In Level 1 your dog learned to find Sweet Birch under one of five pots. Level 2 takes that skill further: further away, around the room, up high, through doorways and out into the garden. The scent, the cue and the reward stay the same. Only the search gets bigger.

Is your dog ready for Level 2?

They find the Birch tin under five shuffled pots in at least 4 of 5 searches, on two separate days, and stay loose and keen while doing it. Not quite there? Do a few more sessions of Level 1 Days 4 and 5. There's no rush.



Scentwork pipes on their wooden bases. The scent tin sits inside one of them.

Handler tips

Do this

- Change one thing at a time: distance, room or height.
- Stay behind your dog and let them lead.
- Reward at the pipe the moment they nose-touch it.
- Say "Search" again after a find if there's more to do.
- End every 5 to 10 minute session on an easy win.

Avoid this

- Pointing at, looking at or walking to the hide.
- Moving on a stage after one good day.
- Leaving the scented pipe out between sessions.
- Searching when your dog is tired, unwell or wound up.
- Rewarding the empty pipes.

Reading your dog in a bigger space

What you see	What it usually means
Head up, nose high, slowing down	Caught the scent in the air. Give them space.
Zig-zagging back and forth	Working the edges of the scent to find its source.
Circling one area, tail moving faster	Getting close. Stay still and quiet.
Firm nose-touch on one pipe	Found it. Reward straight away at the pipe.
Wandering off, sniffing at random	Lost the scent, or the step was too big. Make the next search easier.
Panting, jumping, scanning, sticking to you	Over threshold. Stop, settle, and finish with a Level 1 pot search.

Especially for nervous dogs

- **Stay in the safe room** for Stages 1 to 4. Only go to a new room or the garden once your dog is relaxed there anyway.
- **Calm counts more than finds.** A dog who finds the pipe but looks tense hasn't passed the stage yet.
- **Be boring and still.** Move slowly behind your dog and don't crowd them at the find. Keep visitors, other dogs and sudden noise away.
- **Outdoors,** use a long line, choose a quiet time of day, and start close to the house door.

Getting started

What you need

- **5 scentwork pipes** on bases, ideally with covers. We like the ones from The Sniffer Shop (thesniffershop.co.uk).
- **Your Level 1 kit:** Sweet Birch, tweezers and scent tins.
- **A long line** (5 to 10 m) for the garden and days out.
- **Small, tasty treats.** Optional: a small magnetic scent tin for hides on a car.

The "hot" pipe

Pick one pipe to be the scented one and mark it discreetly, for example with a band of tape on the base. The other four pipes always stay blank and must never hold scent. That way your dog learns to find the Birch, not the pipe. Use tweezers to drop the Birch tin into the hot pipe, then put the cover on.

Safety first

- All scentwork oils, Sweet Birch included, are harmful if swallowed. The scent stays in a closed tin, and the tin stays in a pipe.
- Keep bottles closed and out of reach. Put the pipes and tins away after every session, and pick the pipe up after each find.
- Sugar-free gum can smell like Birch and may contain xylitol, which is poisonous to dogs. Keep it out of reach.
- Search outdoors only in fenced areas, away from bins, food scraps and anything your dog shouldn't pick up.

The Level 2 rule: move on to the next stage only when your dog has found the hot pipe in at least 4 of 5 searches, on two separate days, while looking relaxed. If they struggle, go back one stage. Going back is part of training, not a failure. Most dogs spend about a week on each stage.

Progression: Stage 1 to Stage 6

STAGE 1

Meet the pipes

SET UP Stand the 5 pipes in a line about 30 cm apart, in your old pot spot. Shuffle the order between searches.

WHAT TO DO On lead, say "Search" and walk the line behind your dog. Reward the nose-touch at the hot pipe. Calmly carry on past any blank pipe your dog checks.

Move on when: **4 of 5 finds on two days, with no interest in the blank pipes.**

STAGE 2

Spread out

SET UP Widen the gaps a little each session, from 30 cm up to 1 to 3 m. Then try a loose circle or a zig-zag.

WHAT TO DO Let your dog choose the route, with a slack lead. If they miss the hot pipe, start a new, easier search.

Move on when: **your dog checks the pipes in turn without being guided.**

STAGE 3

The whole room

SET UP A small, familiar room with the door shut. Put just the hot pipe on the floor beside furniture. Later, add everyday objects such as a shoe, a bag or a box.

WHAT TO DO Always start from the same spot by the door. Begin with the pipe in plain sight, then move it to quieter corners.

Move on when: **your dog finds the pipe without a row of pipes to follow.**

STAGE 4

High and low

SET UP Move the hot pipe onto a chair seat, a low shelf or a step, or behind a cushion. Always keep it where your dog's nose can reach it safely.

WHAT TO DO Your dog may circle underneath before lifting their nose. Wait, say nothing, and reward the moment they reach the pipe.

Move on when: **your dog indicates calmly at different heights.**

STAGE 5

Through the door

SET UP Put the hot pipe just inside a second room your dog knows, then deeper in. Then try a scented pipe in each of two rooms, using a second Birch tin.

WHAT TO DO After the first find, say "Search" again and go to the next room. If your dog goes back to a pipe they've already found, praise them but don't reward again.

Move on when: **your dog settles after a find and happily searches again.**

STAGE 6

Into the garden

SET UP Choose a fenced garden on a calm, dry day. Stand the hot pipe on a patio or flat lawn 3 to 5 m from the start, then up to 10 m away. Add the blank pipes, with covers on.

WHAT TO DO Use a long line. Wind carries the scent away from the pipe, so your dog may pick it up downwind and work back to it. Keep early sessions short.

Move on when: **your dog searches the garden reliably and finishes happy.**

Away from home: decompression days

A decompression day is a quiet day after something stressful, such as a vet visit, a busy weekend or a scare on a walk. Sniffing is one of the best ways for a dog to unwind. Once your dog has done Stage 6, you can take the pipes out with you. Use an easy Stage 1 or 2 set-up, so it feels relaxing, not like a test.

A secure field

- Book a private slot, so no other dogs or people arrive.
- Walk the fence line first and check the gate is shut.
- Start with the pipes near the gate, and spread them out on later visits.
- Use a long line unless your dog's recall is reliable there. Give them a free sniff of the field before the first search.

Around the car

- Find a quiet spot away from traffic, with the engine off and the car cool.
- Stand the pipes by a wheel, by the bumper and beside the boot.
- For a hide on the car itself, use a small magnetic scent tin low on the bodywork, for example just above a wheel arch. The pipes aren't made to fix to a car.
- Keep your dog on lead, and never put a hide under the car. This is great before or after a journey your dog finds hard.

Always bring every pipe and tin home with you.

Your Level 2 log

Date	Stage	Where (room, height, distance)	Found (x of 5)	Relaxed (1 to 5)	Notes

Coming next: Level 3, A Second Scent

Once your dog is a confident searcher, Level 3 adds Anise, using the same Day 1 to Day 5 steps you already know.

Flo4Paws · Bingham, Nottinghamshire · www.flo4paws.co.uk · Specialising in nervous and anxious dogs · BCCS Level 4 Canine Behaviour Diploma · Inspired by *Scent Training for Every Dog* by Dr Rob Hewings.